BRITISH COUNCIL

English Online

LIVE25

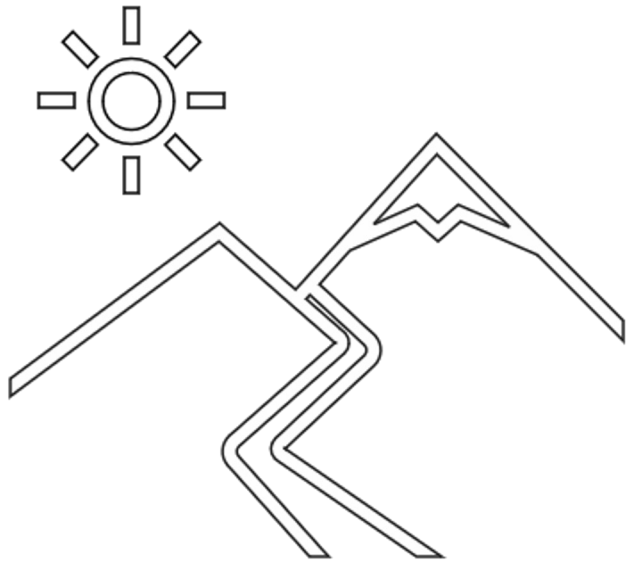
Pronunciation:
consonant clusters



Introduction

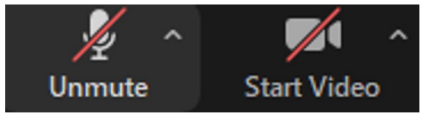
Welcome to Pronunciation Live25!

- **A new feature of English Online**
- **Free pronunciation presentations**
- **Download the PDF after booking**
- **Practise on mute**
- **Sit back and enjoy the ride!**



Please be on mute

You can keep your cams off



Lead-in

How many 5-letter words do you know that end in –ft?

For example: shift, theft

Type your examples in Chat now – you have 1 minute!



Let’s focus

Let’s look at some of the examples…

shift	/ʃɪft/
theft	/θeft/
swift	/swɪft/

Stay on mute and copy the pronunciation of your teacher. Is the –ft ending easy or difficult for you to pronounce? Write your answer in Chat.

Form

Consonant clusters occur when *a group of consonant sounds (two or more) has no vowel between them*.

For example, look at the word splits:

splits /splɪts/ **‘spl’ and ‘ts’ are consonant clusters.**

***At the beginning of words*, three letters is the longest possible consonant cluster.**

***The longest possible final consonant cluster* is five (angsts) but four is more common (bursts, sixths, twelfths).**

Some beginning consonant clusters

bl /bl/	**br /br/**	**cl /kl/**	**cr /kr/**	**dr /dr/**	**fl /fl/**	**fr /fr/**
blue	brunch	clothes	crack	drive	float	freeze
gl /gl/	**gr /gr/**	**pl /pl/**	**pr /pr/**	**sk /sk/**	**sl /sl/**	**sm /sm/**
glue	grade	plural	prize	skirt	slow	smart
sn /sn/	**sp /sp/**	**st /st/**	**sw /sw/**	**tr /tr/**	**tw /tw/**	**scr /skr/**
snake	special	step	swim	trick	tweet	scrap
shr /ʃr/	**sph /sf/**	**spl /spl/**	**spr /spr/**	**squ /skw/**	**str /str/**	**thr /θr/**
shrink	sphere	splash	spray	squeeze	strong	throw

Some ending consonant clusters

ct /kt/	**ft /ft/**	**ld /ld/**	**lf /lf**
product	swift	cold	shelf
nt /nt/	**nk /nk/**	**lp /lp/**	**lth /lθ/**
scant	drink	help	stealth
lt /lt/	**st /st/**	**sp /sp/**	**mp /mp/**
wilt	last	spell	stamp
nd /nd/	**pt /pt/**	**lk /lk/**	
stand	accept	milk	
xt /kst/	**nch /ntʃ/**		
next	lunch		

Examples

Can you give any more examples?

Write them in the chat

Practice

In your next English Online class:

1) **Be on mute and practise saying them to yourself.**

After classes, try these activities:

1) **Practise ‘minimal pairs’ (see the examples on the next slide).**
2) **Recording yourself saying this tongue twister repeatedly:**

The sixth twisty crisp

Minimal Pairs

Say these pairs of words to help you pronounce consonant clusters better. Practise some with your teacher now.

pot / spot

pill / spill

wing / swing

tack / stack

key / ski

bake / break

bed / bread

fog / frog

tea / tree

call / crawl

box / blocks

bow / blow

four / floor

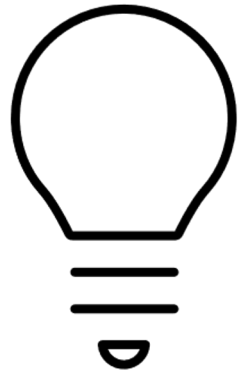
go / glow

Key point

Consonant clusters are typically two or three consonants long. There won't be any vowel sounds within them.

Pronunciation tip:

Be careful of plural nouns and third person verbs: they add an 's'!



Pronunciation Checkout

Look at the consonant clusters below. They are all *sounds* that begin or end words. Write examples in Chat.

1. **Sl- /sl/**
2. **Thr- /θr/**
3. **-xt /kst/**



Pronunciation Checkout - Answers

Look at the consonant clusters below. They are all *sounds* that begin or end words. Write examples in Chat.

1. **Sl- /sl/** Slick, slow, slim, slang
2. **Thr- /θr/** Through, throw
3. **-xt /kst/** Next, text, subtext, context

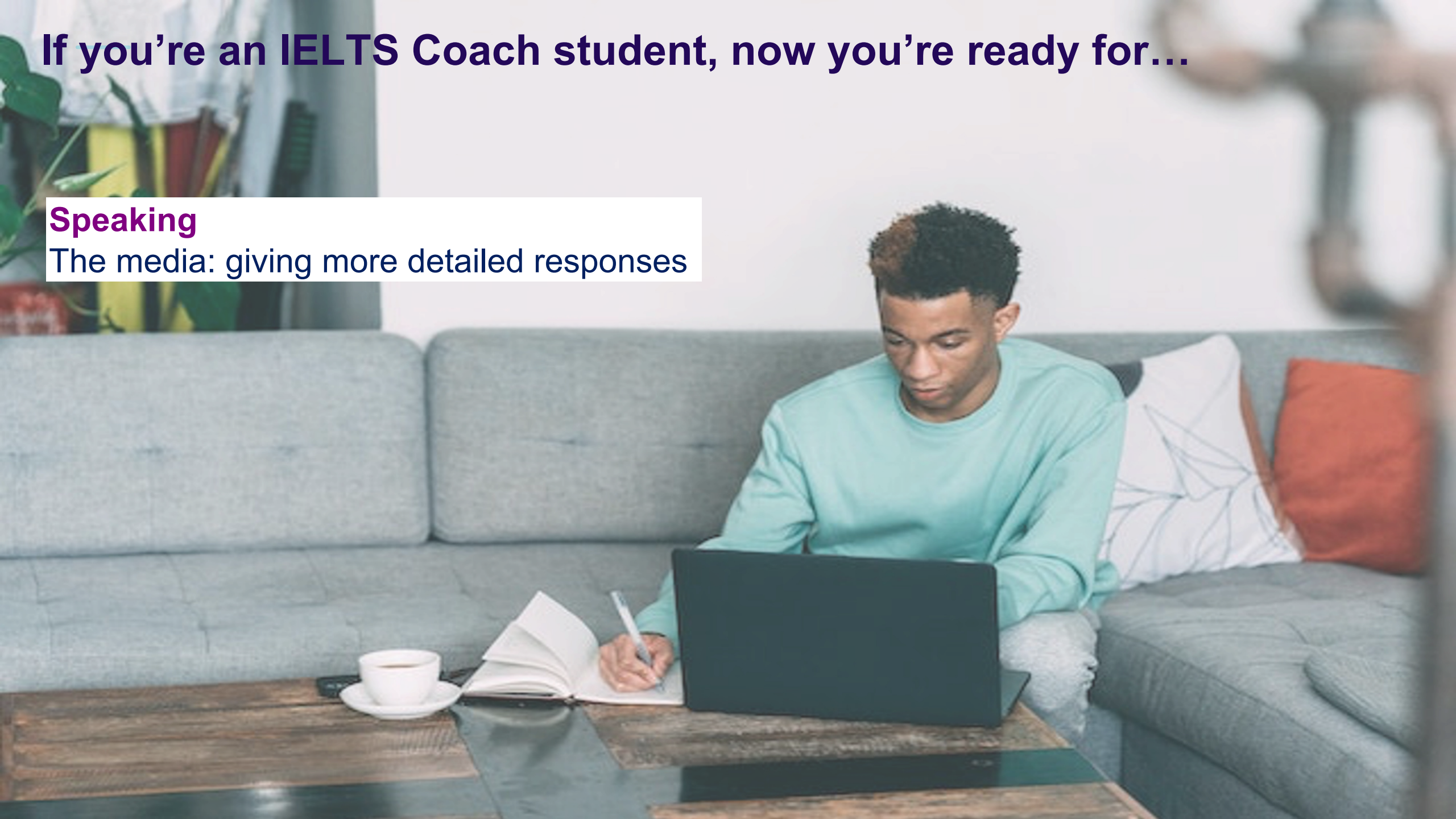


Thank you for attending this presentation!

Review the next few slides for lessons linked to this Live25 webinar.

https://www.thefreedictionary.com/words-that-end-in-ft

If you’re an IELTS Coach student, now you’re ready for…



Speaking

The media: giving more detailed responses

If you’re an English Online student, now you’re ready for…



Elementary
Theme: Things around us
Lesson: My things

Pre-intermediate
Theme: Restaurants and shopping
Lesson: Describing objects

Intermediate
Theme: Home, holidays and tourism
Lesson: A memorable holiday

Upper intermediate
Theme: Culture, humour and language
Lesson: Happiness

Advanced
Theme: Business communication
Lesson: Staff morale

If you're an English for Work student, now you're ready for…



Elementary
Theme: Networking
Lesson: Your impressions

Pre-intermediate
Theme: New ideas and opportunities
Lesson: You and your job

Intermediate
Theme: Ready to work
Lesson: Strengths and weaknesses

Upper intermediate
Theme: Working with clients
Lesson: Your ideal company

Advanced
Theme: Product research and development
Lesson: Technical descriptions